Losers' Consent and Anti-Systemic Protest: Experimental Evidence from Chile

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- While research has looked into "losers' consent," focusing on satisfaction, trust, and efficacy.
- The "**losers' consent**" **literature has not studied the propensity to support anti-systemic protests**.

Our Contribution: A descriptive experimental study of Chile, and a "Shadow Case"

- We analyze the level of system support among electoral losers using novel data from a conjoint experiment in Chile (N=811).

☞ We use the Estonian (N=639) case as a ***shadow case*** to contrast the Chilean case (Mahoney & Goertz, 2006).

- We exploit institutional heterogeneities (presidential v. parliamentary systems).
- We pre-registered the following hypotheses: ▸ link

  H1 Electoral losers favor candidates endorsing anti-systemic protests more than winners.

  H2 This tendency is stronger in presidential than in parliamentary systems.

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Theoretical Background

1. **Social movements**:
   - *"Angry" losers* might be more willing to support anti-systemic politicians. (Bowler, Donovan, and Karp 2007)
   - Winners (who draw instrumental benefits from the system) should oppose politicians supporting anti-systemic actions.
   - ☞ Loser's consent: introduce the case of **violent protests**.

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   - ☞ Loser's consent: introduce the case of **violent protests**.
2. **Institutional literature**: institutional setups affect differently the costs of losing an election (Lijphart, 2012).
   - **Presidential**: losers have little input outside of the electoral cycle.
   - **Parliamentary**: losers' interests can be represented through a variety of power sharing institutions.
   - ☞ Thus, in presidential systems, the stakes are higher, creating more incentives to oppose the government via **violent protests**.

Case Selection

- Collected novel data from Chile (N=811) and Estonia (N=639).
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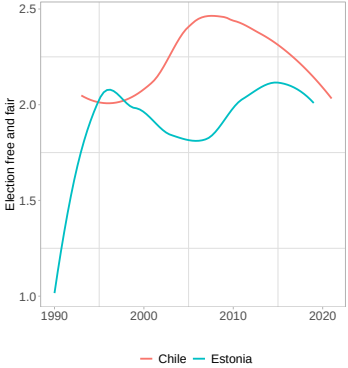

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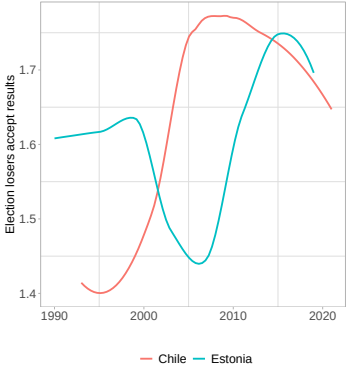

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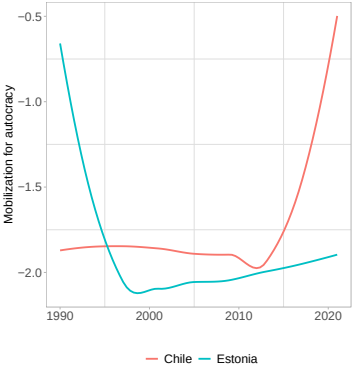

Conjoint Experiment

- Designed an unconstrained, fully randomized conjoint experiment.
- We explored if **hypothetical** (conjoint) **candidates** who support violent protests receive different levels of support from **actual winning and losing participants**.
- We depart from standard AMCE analyses (Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014) and instead compute **subgroup marginal means** (Leeper, Hobolt, and Tilley 2020).

Attribute Set

Dimension	Attribute Set
Gender	Male, Female.
Age	Younger than 35, Between 35-50, Over 50.
Protest	The candidate OPPOSES anti-government protest that will seek to de-destabilize the current government, The candidate SUPPORTS anti-government protest that will seek to de-destabilize the current government
Pensions	The candidate OPPOSES increases in pensions for the elderly, The candidate SUPPORTS increases in pensions for the elderly

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Conjoint Experiment: An Hypothetical Example

- Respondents were asked to choose between two options. For **example**:

Candidate 1	**Candidate 2**
Female Over 50 The candidate OPPOSES anti-government protest that will seek to de-destabilize the current government The candidate OPPOSES increases in pensions for the elderly	Female Between 35-50 The candidate SUPPORTS anti-government protest that will seek to de-destabilize the current government The candidate OPPOSES increases in pensions for the elderly
`Please, choose one candidate`	

- Respondents repeated this process 8 times.
- **Every time, cells change their content at random**.

Winning and Losing Statuses: How we measured them

- **Losers/Winners**: asked who respondents voted for **in the last (real) election**.
  - **Chile**: "*Which candidate did you vote for in the 2nd round of the December 2021 presidential election?*"
    `Kast`, `Boric`, `Others` (`Blank/Spoiled`, `I did not vote`, `Prefer not to say`).
  - **Estonia**: "*Which political party did you vote for in the [March 2023 parliamentary election]?*"

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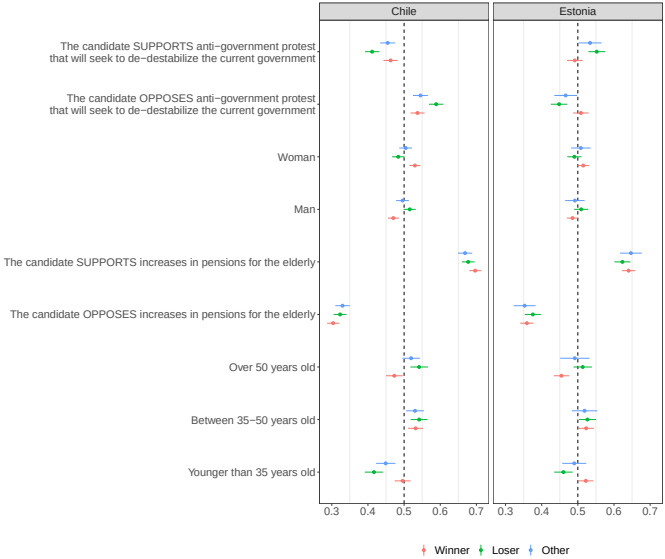
- (Hypothetical) Candidates **favoring violent protests** are systematically **rejected** by (actual) winners *and* losers.
- **Legacy effects**: results are driven by the legacies of the 2019-20 protests (*'Social Unrest'*).
- **Losers (Kast)** show even **stronger disapproval** of violent protests.



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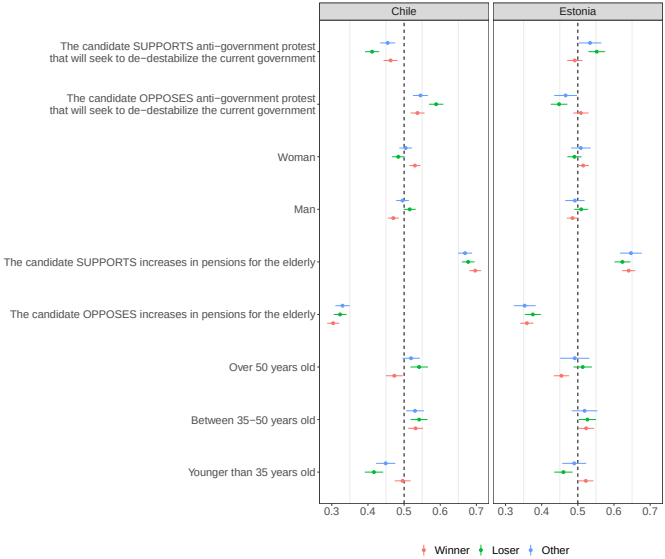

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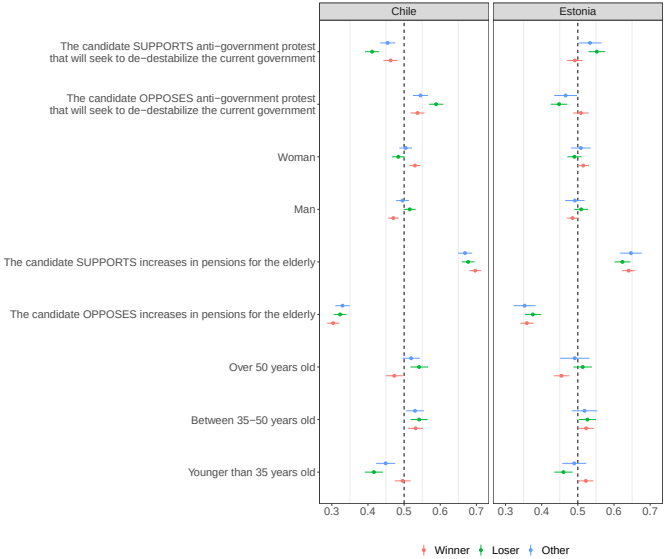

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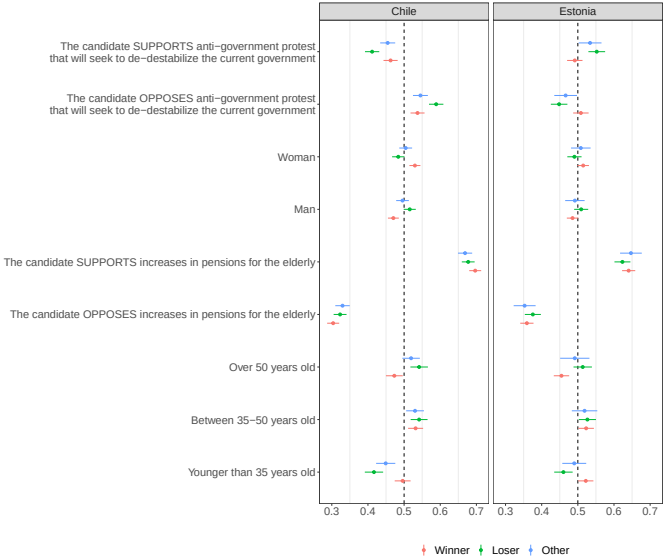

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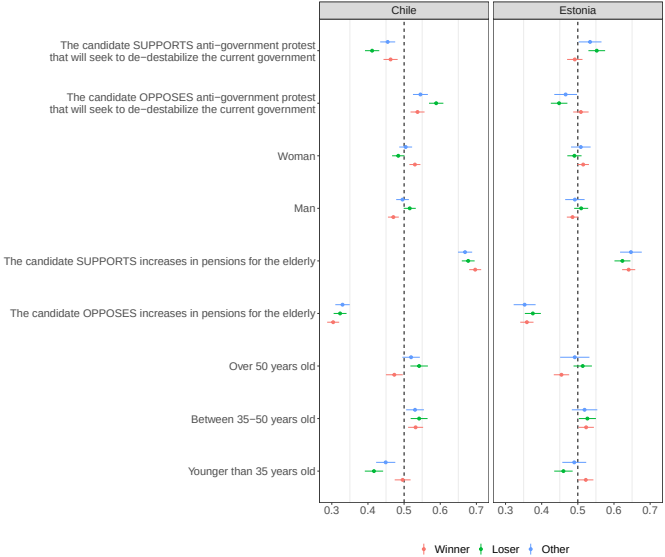
- (Hypothetical) Candidates **favoring violent protests** are systematically **supported** by (actual) losers.
- **Losers' Effect**: mainly driven by anti-migrant and anti-LGBT extreme right EKRE voters.
- **Disengaged citizens**: favor candidates proposing violent protests.



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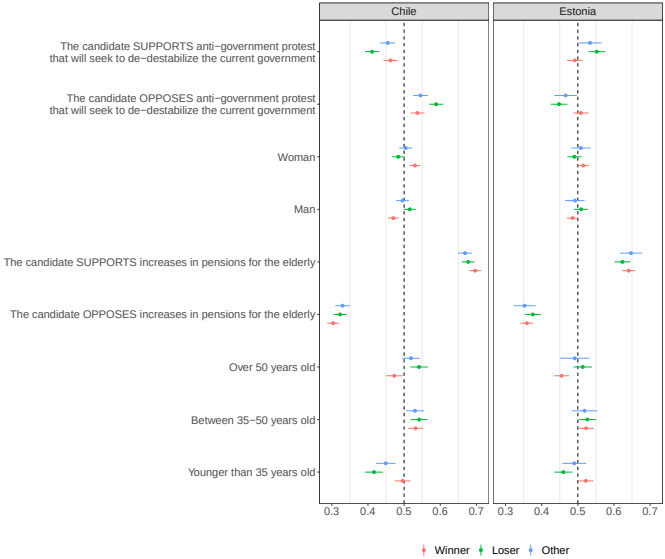

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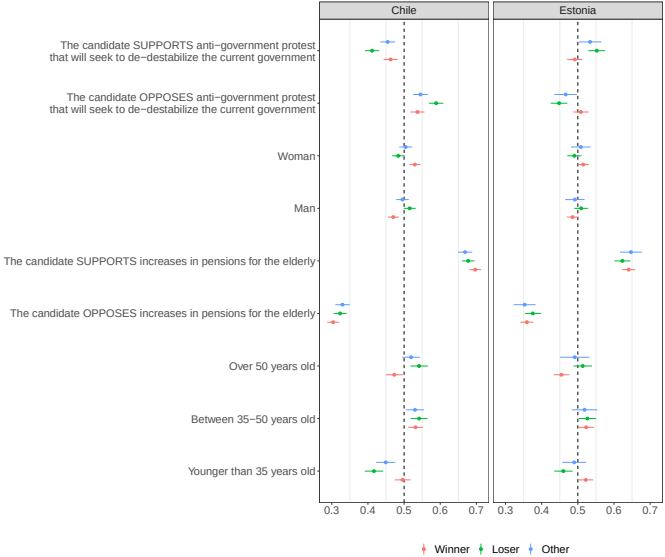

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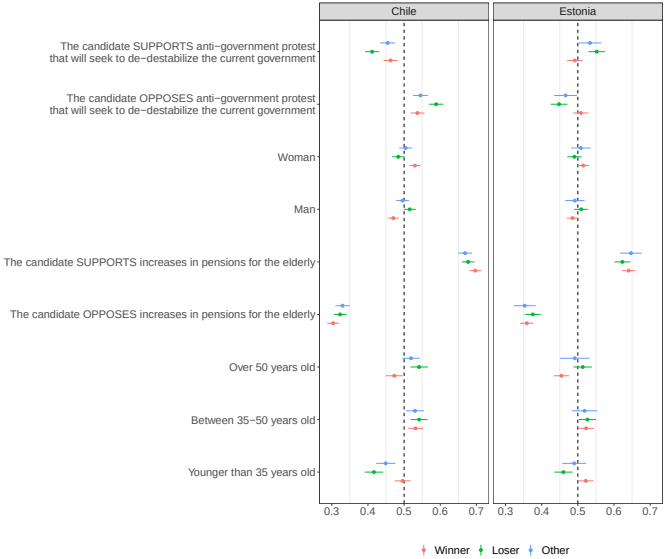

Discussion: More Questions Than Answers

- We hypothesized (and pre-registered) that:
  - H1 *Electoral losers* were *more* willing to support anti-systemic protests.
  - H2 This effect would be *stronger* in Presidential systems.

    Losses are more catastrophic.
- While we did not find support in favor of our hypotheses, we still found other interesting results.
  - **Chile**: Extreme-right supporters (losers) are less likely to support violent protests.
  - **Estonia**: Extreme-right supporters (losers) are more likely to support violent protests.

Experimento Fallido? Metimos la pata?

De una manera, es un experimento fallido:

Did we make a mistake to think that, **in Chile (!)**, right-wing losers were going to **protests** (!)?

- Qué otras maneras ven de "salvar" el paper?
- Actualmente, el paper está *framed* **no como un error en la selección de caso**, pero sí como un ***red flag*** de lo potente que fue la herencia del *Estallido Social*.
- El paper esta **enviado** en *Research & Politics*.
- **Thoughts?**

Thank you

to check updates on this project.